



Civil Society Network on Migration and Development *(CSOnetMADE)*

United for Voluntary, Safe and Dignified Migration

South East Migration Dialogue (SEMD) 2026 *Promoting Regular Migration; Strengthening Sub-National Migration Governance for the* *Implementation of the 2025 National Migration Policy*

Concept note

Background

Migration is a complex and evolving phenomenon shaped by diverse drivers, ranging from economic transitions, demographic pressures, environmental change, insecurity, and global socio-political dynamics. These forces continue to influence internal and international migration patterns creating the need for a responsive and inclusive governance structure

A 2022 review led by Civil Society Organizations on the 2nd and 3rd levels of the governance structure of the 2015 National Migration Policy further uncovered key weaknesses within these levels of coordination, including inter-agency rivalry, poor information flow, weak feedback mechanisms, and limited capacity for coordination across state and non-state actors. These structural gaps have undermined effective migration management and exposed a significant disconnect between national policy and local realities

Responding to these dynamics and evolving trends, Nigeria developed the National Migration Policy (NMP) in 2015 as a foundational document to harmonize efforts across sectors and institutions. The policy aimed to address the full spectrum of migration-related issues including labor migration, irregular migration, trafficking in persons, displacement, and diaspora engagement. It also provided a National Migration Governance structure to enhance coordination and collaboration efforts on migration.

However, implementation experience over the years has revealed gaps, particularly in the translation of national policy objectives into actionable strategies at the local level. States and local governments, despite being on the frontlines of migration realities, were not explicitly integrated into the migration governance structure. This challenge has had significant implications for operational coordination, data sharing, and localized response mechanisms

In line with the policy's provision for a five-year review cycle, Nigeria commenced the review process of the 2015 NMP in 2022, incorporating extensive zonal consultations to capture regional peculiarities and trends. A recurring challenge during these engagements was the absence of a state level structure, limiting grassroots participation and creating an urgent need to decentralize migration governance for more context-responsive, inclusive implementation.

The 2024 Civil Society Forum (CSF) on Migration and Development echoed these findings, emphasizing the lack of structured coordination at the state level and identifying local funding gaps as a persistent barrier to localized migration responses. These insights shaped a critical outcome of the revised policy.

The Revised National Migration Policy, 2025 addresses these identified challenges and gaps by introducing a fourth level of governance, state-level coordination structure, providing a framework for formally integrating state and local actors into the national migration governance. This inclusion demonstrates Nigeria's commitment to the whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach while emphasizing decentralization, bottom-up participation, ensuring that migration governance is closer to the grassroots.

To translate this policy provision into action, non-state actors, particularly civil society organizations, are strategically positioned to lead this approach. Their grassroots presence, commitment and trust among local populations make them ideal drivers of decentralization. By leveraging the Civil Society Forum on Migration and Development (CSF), a platform that unites a wide range of non-state actors on migration and development in Nigeria, CSOs can initiate the institutionalization of the decentralized governance frameworks across Nigeria.

Furthermore, to ensure the sustainability of decentralization efforts and effectively address the persistent challenge of inadequate local funding, a key strategy will be the intentional engagement of the private sector, particularly at the grassroots level through corporate social responsibility initiatives, investment in local livelihoods, and support for service delivery, thereby transforming migration governance from policy to sustainable practice. Their participation not only enhances local ownership but also introduces innovative and sustainable financing models for migration-related interventions.

Against this backdrop, the 2025 Civil Society Forum (CSF) presented a timely and strategic opportunity to both sensitize stakeholders particularly non-state actors on the Revised National Migration Policy, 2025 and co-create a unified roadmap for operationalizing the state level of Nigeria's migration governance structure.

South East Relevance:

Youth unemployment and perceived lack of opportunity are major drivers of irregular migration from the South East. Without formal platforms for information, training, and safe pathways, young people increasingly resort to irregular routes and upon return, many of these returnees

face limited opportunities, which can perpetuate cycles of re-migration unless addressed through targeted reintegration support including skills development, psychosocial support, and livelihood opportunities.

- **High Migration Propensity:** The 2022 World Bank Migration and Development Brief notes that Nigeria remains the top recipient of remittances in Sub-Saharan Africa, with a significant portion flowing to the Southeast. The 2018/2019 Nigeria Immigration Service (NIS) data indicates that Anambra, Imo, and Abia states are among the top origins for international passport applications. According to recent data, Nigeria received approx. **\$23 billion** in official remittances in 2025. Unofficial estimates suggest nearly 40-50% of these flows are destined for the South East, serving as a *de facto* social safety net. However, less than 5% of these funds are channeled into structured investment as most go to consumption.
- **Irregular Migration Risks:** Data from the Nigeria Immigration Service and IOM suggests that South Eastern states (specifically Imo, and Abia including Edo, Delta regions) are consistent 'sending areas' for both regular and irregular migrants. These regions are challenged with a 'youth bulge' where over 60% of the population is under 30, facing high unemployment and a primary source of vulnerable migrants, including victims of trafficking according to a 2023 IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix (DTM) report. South Eastern youths are statistically overrepresented in detention centers in Libya and among casualties at sea, driven by misinformation from local trafficking syndicates.
- **Brain Drain vs. Brain Gain:** The south eastern region continues to lose critical mass in the health and education sectors. There is currently no unified sub-national policy in Abia or neighboring states to engage the high-skilled diaspora for either 'skills transfer' or 'tele-medicine' initiatives.
- **Subnational Governance Gap:** Migration governance in Nigeria remains overly centralized. State and local governments lack the legal mandate, institutional capacity, data systems, and dedicated resources to effectively manage migration's local drivers and impacts. This disconnect have hindered the development of context-specific solutions for job creation, skills development, and diaspora engagement.

The South East region of Nigeria is a primary axis of mobility in West Africa. Known for the industriousness of its people, experiencing high rates of emigration, both internal (to Lagos, Abuja, Kano) and international majorly Europe, North America, and Asia. While this mobility drives significant remittance inflows vital to the region's economy, it creates critical governance challenges. The 'Japa' syndrome has accelerated the brain drain of healthcare and tech professionals, while irregular migration routes continue to claim the lives of the region's youth. A zonal dialogue will surface these realities, pledge commitment from regional leadership, and align interventions to reduce risk and vulnerability among young people considering irregular migration.

The Maiden edition of the South East Migration Dialogue (SEMD) 2026, is a strategic, high-level intervention designed to domesticate Nigeria's National Migration Policy at the sub-national

(state) level. It aims to shift the narrative from "stopping migration" to "enhancing migration" for development, ensuring that Abia and its sister states harness the diaspora's potential while curbing the human cost of irregular journeys.

The outcome of the **South East Migration Dialogue (SEMD) 2026** is substantial and feeds into national migration governance strategies, looking at 'Promoting Regular Migration; Strengthening Sub-National Migration Governance' as the South East region's commitment to the whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach.

Objectives of the Zonal Dialogue

The South East Zonal Migration Dialogue aims to:

1. Familiarize migration actors with the validated 2025 National Migration Policy (NMP), ensuring broad understanding and grassroots engagement
2. Translate national and international migration policy frameworks into regionally relevant strategies that respond to specific drivers and patterns in the South East.
3. Engage in strategic advocacy with relevant government bodies contributing to the formal adoption of the validated policy
4. Improve understanding and usage of migration data at sub-national levels to better plan for mobility trends, reintegration needs, labor market impacts, and diaspora engagement
5. Develop CSO-led roadmaps aimed at initiating and institutionalizing decentralized migration governance across south east states, tailored to local migration dynamics and capacities
6. Strengthen collaboration and coordination among state-level government actors, civil society organizations, private sector stakeholders and diaspora networks to co-design strategies for safe, orderly, and regular migration pathways.
7. Promote sustainable local funding mechanisms by actively engaging the private sector, particularly at the grassroots level, to support inclusive, long-term migration governance initiatives

Expected Outcomes

1. Enhanced awareness and understanding of the 2025 National Migration Policy among state and non-state actors across south east's five geopolitical zones
2. Translated migration policy frameworks into a region-specific strategy tailored to South East priorities and resources.
3. Strengthened advocacy, leading to increased government commitment to adopt and implement the decentralized policy framework at the state level
4. Clear recommendations for migration data collection, analysis, and sharing to inform regional planning for mobility trends, reintegration needs, labor market impacts, and diaspora engagement.
5. Developed roadmaps to guide the institutionalization of the state-level migration governance structures of the 2025 National Migration Policy
6. Improved collaboration between civil society, government institutions, and private sector actors to facilitate community awareness campaigns, safer migration pathways, youth

employment linkages, and reintegration support frameworks.

7. Established pathways for sustainable local funding, driven by private sector engagement and social investment in grassroots migration governance

Methodology & Approach

Methodology

The forum brings together civil society organizations, government representatives, international partners, private sector actors and other key stakeholders in migration governance to foster dialogue, strengthen collaboration and promote inclusive, grassroots-led approaches to migration and development in Nigeria.

These activities will culminate in a 3-day physical gathering with zonal representation. The event will feature capacity building sessions, plenary discussions, interactive sessions and thematic breakout groups to develop a practical roadmap that supports the implementation of the 2025 NMP provisions for institutionalizing the state-level coordination mechanism. The roadmap will outline concrete and actionable steps that strengthen decentralization, foster local partnerships and integrate migration priorities into state development planning.

In addition, the forum will include a dedicated private sector engagement segment aimed at exploring and promoting sustainable local funding mechanisms. This session will identify social investment opportunities, corporate responsibility pathways and collaborative models that can strengthen community-level responses, enhance local ownership and ensure long-term sustainability of migration governance interventions.

The event will also provide an enabling environment for networking, relationship-building and strengthening collaboration among stakeholders across the migration governance ecosystem. Together, these coordinated activities will ensure that the SEMB 2026 serves as a catalyst for localized migration governance, fostering inclusive participation, strategic collaboration and sustainable implementation of the 2025 National Migration Policy.

Core Themes and Session Topics

The dialogue should include sessions on:

1. Drivers and Dynamics of Migration in the South East
2. Irregular Migration and Human Security
3. Labor Market Linkages and Youth Mobility
4. Diaspora Engagement and Regional Development
5. Migration Data and Governance Systems
6. Reintegration and Support for Returnees

Conclusion

A South East Zonal Migration Dialogue is not only timely but necessary. Migration is both a challenge and an opportunity for the region. Without proactive and coordinated discussion that reflects regional realities and priorities, the South East risks exacerbated human insecurities, lost human capital, and missed development opportunities. Anchoring these conversations after the National Dialogue will ensure that migration governance becomes inclusive, localized, and

implementable.

AGENDA FOR THE 2026 South East Migration Dialogue (SEMD)

Theme: *Promoting Regular Migration; Strengthening Sub-National Migration Governance*

Date: 21th March 2026

Venue: Michael Okpara Auditorium, Umuahia. Abia State

Main Forum

Time	Activity	Lead / Facilitator
9:00 – 9:30am	Arrival and Registration	All
9:30 – 9:40am	National Anthem	All
9:40 – 9:50am	Welcome Remarks	CSOnetMADE
9:50 – 10:20am		
10:20 – 10:30am		
10:30 – 11:00am		
11:00 – 11:30am		
11:30 - 11:45am		
11:45am 12:30pm		

12:30 – 1:45pm		
1:45 – 2:30pm		
2:30 – 2:45pm		
2:45 - 3:00pm		
3:00 – 3:15pm		
3:15pm		

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